HOOK

Nobody on the team can explain the code in prod

That's not a hypothetical. It's a live argument among developers right now.

- 219 comments on a 125-point HN post this week
- The anxiety is real, not theoretical
- Something shifted and people are noticing

WHAT'S HAPPENING

AI agents write it, humans just approve it

The code ships. The understanding doesn't always ship with it.

- Agents generate working code fast
- Devs review output, not every line's logic
- Approval is getting confused with comprehension

WHY IT'S BLOWING UP

Speed exposed a gap nobody solved first

Agentic coding got fast before review habits caught up.

- Output volume grew faster than review rigor
- 'It works' replaced 'I understand why it works'
- Debugging later costs more than reviewing now

THE REAL SHIFT

The skill moved from writing to validating

Writing code was never the hard part long-term. Trusting it was.

- Reading code carefully is now the core skill
- Explaining a system beats generating one
- Review quality is the new bottleneck

MECHANISM

Where blind trust creeps into a workflow

It's rarely one decision. It's a pattern of small shortcuts.

- Agent proposes, human skims, human merges
- Tests pass so logic goes unquestioned
- No one asks 'why' until something breaks

WHAT GOOD REVIEW LOOKS LIKE

Three habits that keep you in control

None of this is anti-AI. It's pro-accountability.

- Trace the logic path before trusting the output
- Ask the agent to explain its own reasoning
- Keep humans on anything touching money or data

LESSON

Fast code isn't the same as owned code

If you can't explain it, you can't maintain it when it breaks.

- Ownership means you can debug it at 2am
- Unexplainable systems become unmaintainable
- Guardrails matter more as agents get capable

TAKEAWAY

Build review into the workflow, not after it

Treat validation as a designed step, not an afterthought.

- Add explanation checkpoints before merge
- Slow down on logic you didn't write yourself
- Human oversight stays part of the architecture

CTA

How does your team review AI-written code?

Curious what checkpoints people are actually using.

- Drop your review process in the comments
- Happy to compare notes on agent guardrails

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